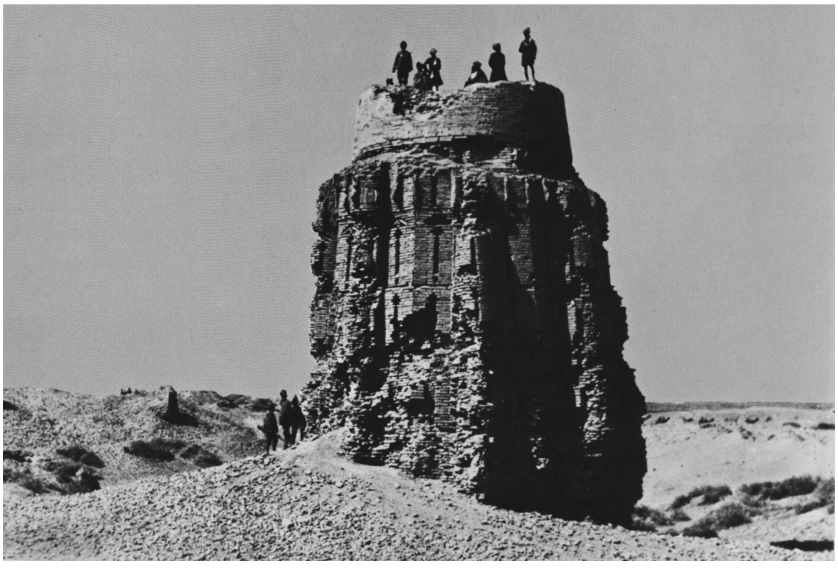


Figure 2.26 *Nad-i Ali, Zaranj, Sistan, remains of tower. From O'Kane 1984, fig. 14c. Photograph T. Ward (early twentieth century) from the Royal Geographical Society, London.*

at Ghazna). In sum, at approximately one-third the height of the Balkh and Qasimabad *minar*s – and probably only one-fourth the height of the Ghazna towers – Da Qadi's *minar* would not have reached the impressive proportions of the works commissioned by royal and elite patrons in the broader region.

Coupled with its comparatively diminutive scale, the Da Qadi tower also had a restricted decorative program. All of the other *minar*s mentioned above exhibit a variety of decorative iconography, ranging from crisp geometry and Kufic epigraphy executed in brick, to dense floral motifs and *naskh* inscriptions executed in stucco.[73] By contrast, Da Qadi's *minar* shows only the geometric motifs resulting from the arrangement of bricks at different angles in series. While the tower could have had a plaster or other veneer with additional decoration, as it stands the structure shows only the remains of brick-based decorative elements.

The not insubstantial differences in scale and decoration between Da Qadi's *minar* and the royal- or elite-patronized parallels at Ghazna and those in the Sistan and Balkh regions – not to mention the *minar* of Jam-Firuzkuh itself (see Chapters 3 and 4) – could lead to the conclusion that the Da Qadi example belonged to a different time period, or even to a different tradition altogether. However, Thomas and his collaborators pointed out that these differences may "indicate limited means and/or technological knowledge."[74] As put forth in the Introduction, an architectural culture should be conceived as a spectrum spanning elite or royal,